

Percussion

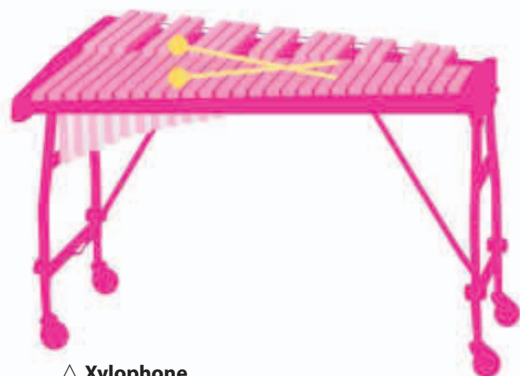
Percussion instruments are not only important soloists but they also form the heart of bands and orchestral ensembles, playing melodies, providing harmony, color, and texture, and driving forward the rhythm.

Orchestral percussion

Orchestral percussion players have to master dozens of different instruments and often have to play them all in one performance. Tuned instruments, such as tubular bells, xylophone, marimba, and vibraphone, mostly play melodies and add color. They are played with sticks or mallets, unlike the celesta, which is operated by a keyboard. Occasionally, one-offs such as a triangle, cowbells, or a thunder sheet may feature for special effects.

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△ Xylophone

The wooden bars of a xylophone are arranged like the keys of a piano keyboard. It is played with two mallets and produces a distinctively hollow sound, effective for solos.

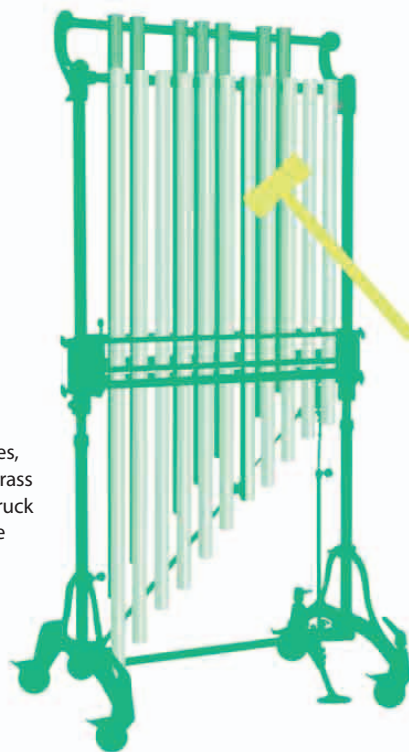


△ Timpani

Timpani, or kettledrums, are tuned by a mechanism that tightens the skin of the head. They are used in pairs, or larger groups in orchestras, to play a range of pitches.

▷ Tubular bells

Also called orchestral bells or chimes, tubular bells are a series of tuned brass tubes graded in length. They are struck with a wooden hammer to produce a sound that easily penetrates the densest musical texture.



▷ Snare drum

Snare drums are double-headed, with string “snare” stretched across one of the drum heads. When the other head is struck, it produces a rattling effect.



△ Cymbals

Cymbals are plates of brass with a narrow rim and a convex center. They can either be clashed together, or struck with a stick or brush.



△ Celesta

The celesta consists of a set of steel bars which are struck with hammers by means of a simplified piano mechanism.